

All the lines, Dalhousie insisted, had to have a single, standard gauge. He was drawing from his experience of the British Railways and its challenges. Consulting engineer of the Indian administration, FW Simms, supported him. While the East India Company (EIC) wanted to go with a 4 ft 8½ in gauge, they were not too picky. Dalhousie, who preferred 6 ft, was open to suggestions, as long as there was a single gauge used across the country. Simms recommended a broad gauge measuring 5 ft 6 in as he felt that it was most suited to India. The severe storms and winds, he noted, could topple a narrow-gauge train, but not the more stable broad gauge. It helped that the latter was more economical. Work began in earnest and it seemed that gauges were no longer a matter of concern.

Connecting the dots

Construction began in the Bengal and Bombay Presidencies and, by 1856, the first lines opened for the public. The returns were quite profitable, with many Indians taking to train travel quickly, reaffirming Dalhousie's stance that the railways did have some use in India. Meanwhile, the British, who had made inroads into Burma, felt an urgent need to build a connection between Calcutta and Dacca (now Dhaka, Bangladesh), and Dacca and Akyab (now Sittwe, Myanmar). The Revolt of 1857 (see [Revolts and The Railways](#)) further emphasized the urgency of building lines that would allow for quick movement of troops. By 1858, political control shifted to the Crown and construction efforts accelerated.

Between 1853 and 1862, several guaranteed companies established themselves. Of these, the Great Indian Peninsula Railway (GIPR) and East Indian Railway (EIR) had already started work on the Bombay and Bengal lines, respectively. The third, Madras Railway, received the contract to build the entire system of Madras trunk lines, towards the west coast, where it would meet the Bombay line, and the north-west. The first train service in the south, a journey of about 100 km, finally started in 1856, between Royapuram in Madras and Wallajah Road in Arcot. The Great Southern India Railway, registered in 1858, built lines from Nagapattinam to Tiruchirappalli.